I walk out to the middle. Unfortunately, sometimes the script doesn't go quite according to plan …

And then there's the physical training, which is one area where I reckon I've managed to work harder than most. I think a common perception exists that cricketers have it all laid out for them; that, like golfers, cricketers don't have to be in peak physical shape to perform well. Judging by the waistlines of some of my colleagues over the years, I can certainly see where that perception comes from. Sure, you don't have to be super-fit to be a cricketer, given that the game – especially as a batsman – is about hand-eye coordination, reflexes and a good *kop*.

But it does help. Bat out there for hours in the heat and humidity of the Indian subcontinent or the West Indies, and all that natural talent you have been relying on won't help you when you start to cramp up or see little black dots dance in front of your eyes when you're exhausted.

So ja, I have made a point of working hard to stay in shape. During time off between tournaments, I'm always at the gym. I do weights in the morning and then go back in the evening to do cardio on the treadmill. I never really run on the road, as I find it too jarring on my lower back and knees. You'll often see me at the Virgin Active in Green Point or the Sports Science Institute in Newlands at 8 p.m. or 9 p.m. at night, working the treadmill.

And that's after I've had supper too. There have been a lot of times after dinner when my mates have suggested that we go out, but I've turned them down because I had to go to the gym. I also value the peace and quiet at that time of the night. It allows me to go through some of my visualisation techniques.

I haven't changed my routine in 20 years. If there are no games during the week, I'll be at the gym four times a week. I'll do almost an hour of cardio – either run for half an hour and cycle for another half an hour, or I'll run for 40 minutes and cycle for 20 minutes. A lot of the guys train differently, but it is a routine I have settled into and stuck with. With all the drinking and partying I've done through the years, it's also really helped to keep me lean.

I'm always trying to instil this kind of work ethic into some of the younger guys in the Cape Cobras team. I always wanted to be fit; I always wanted to show my athleticism on the field. I never took those things for granted. I get a little frustrated with some of the guys who seem satisfied